hereditary regional chiefs (like the *nayanar*s of Tamil country), who understandably resented the outsiders and their disruption of the old social order, especially in the sixteenth century. However, in many distant parts of the empire, local chiefs continued to rule almost independently and kept their hereditary privileges, either just paying ritual homage to their imperial overlords or also contributing arms and revenue.

In certain areas, the governors encountered no regional chiefs. Local power there was more decentralized, split across families of landed caste elites (Brahmins and Vellalars in Tamil country, Kammas and Reddis in Telugu country, etc.), who monopolized local resources and wealth, while exploiting the labour of untouchable castes in exchange for food and shelter. These elites, too, resented the upstarts, the governors, though some parlayed their privileges into lucrative niches in the emerging order—as scribes, bankers and accountants (much as they would with the new professions of the colonial period). Mirroring such integrative forces, even village guardian deities, often goddesses of harvests and fertility, began to be 'Sanskritized' as variants of the more majestic divinities of Vijayanagar's Hindu pantheon. This reconfiguring of older customs and political economy would continue well into the British era and beyond.

Notably, the imperial governors resided in fortified garrisons and maintained standing armies, which were expected to join Vijayanagar's wars against its external enemies and to quell internal revolts by local chiefs or the sporadic peasant revolt. Governors who broke away to set up their own sovereign domains, or 'nayaka kingdoms', also attracted the king's wrath. But after the sacking of Vijayanagar in 1565, the floodgates on this trend opened wide, leading to many independent kingdoms (a process that resembled the earlier disintegration of the Bahmani Sultanate). The largest among them were at Mysore, Ikkeri, Gingee, Tanjore and Madurai. With its complex weave of disruptions and continuities, the Vijayanagar era, writes Stein, 'saw the transition of South Indian society from its medieval past to its modern future'.

Textures of Religious and Courtly Life

One morning, I wander deep inside the Sacred Centre to the lovely and forlorn Achyutaraya's temple complex built in the 1530s. It lies in a valley